

Question:- The demand for smaller states reflects both democratic aspirations and administrative desperation. Critically examine this statement in light of India's federal structure, regional inequalities, and cultural diversity.

Answer:- The creation of smaller states in India is often driven by democratic aspirations such as addressing regional grievances and promoting greater participation in governance. However, the process can also lead to administrative challenges including the need to establish new infrastructure, civil services and financial resources.

Democratic aspiration can be addressed by:-

- ① Addressing Regional Grievances → Regional issues should be the priority taken care of on priority basis as demand for smaller states always stem from specific regional issues such as language, culture or economic disparities.
Ex → Marathwada in Maharashtra.
- ② Promoting Participatory democracy:- Smaller states can potentially facilitate more localized governance and greater participation in decision making.
- ③ Empowering marginalized group - New state can empower previously marginalized or neglected region.
Ex → Bifurcation of Jharkhand from Bihar.

- ④ Decentralized Governance:- promotes equal participation which inturn promotes a sense of ownership and belongingness.
- * feeling of exclusion will be diminished.
- These things will lead to strong federalism and ultimately strengthen nationhood.

- ⑤ Cultural Consolidation:- Preservation of identity
- * Smaller states help protect ethno-linguistic homogeneity ensuring the preservation of cultural and linguistic identity.
 - * Avoiding cultural Erosion:- Prevents the dilution of local culture against larger cosmopolitan city settings.

- ⑥ Reduction of Regional ~~Chauvinism~~ Chauvinism:-

→ mitigating subnational tension:- Addressing statehood demand helps reduce centrifugal political pressure on Union.

→ Strengthening Unity:- Reduces internal conflicts stemming from regional disparities.

Administrative Desperation.

1) Administrative Proliferation: -

- * Increased Cost → redundant bureaucracies, institutional duplication, escalating cost of governance.
- * Complex Hierarchies → Red tapism and multi layered administration can hinder efficiency.

2) Political Balkanization: →

- * Risk of fragmentation: - lead to political atomization and weakening national unity.
- * Federal Equilibrium Threat: - Smaller states strengthen centrifugal tendencies disrupting federal balance.

3) Resource dispute: -

- * Interstate Contentions: - Dividing states often leads to disputes over water, energy and minerals, fostering administrative ~~dead~~ roadblocks.

Ex → Cauvery River dispute b/w Tamil Nadu and Karnataka.

4) Political opportunism - Statehood movements often become tool for regional political elites, prioritizing sub-regional populism over national priorities.

Ex - Jharkhand Mukti Morcha.

5) Economic Disequilibrium:- Smaller states with weaker economies become reliant on fiscal transfers, perpetuating developmental lag.

* Uneven growth:- Economic inequality between states may widen.

6) Strategic Vulnerabilities:-

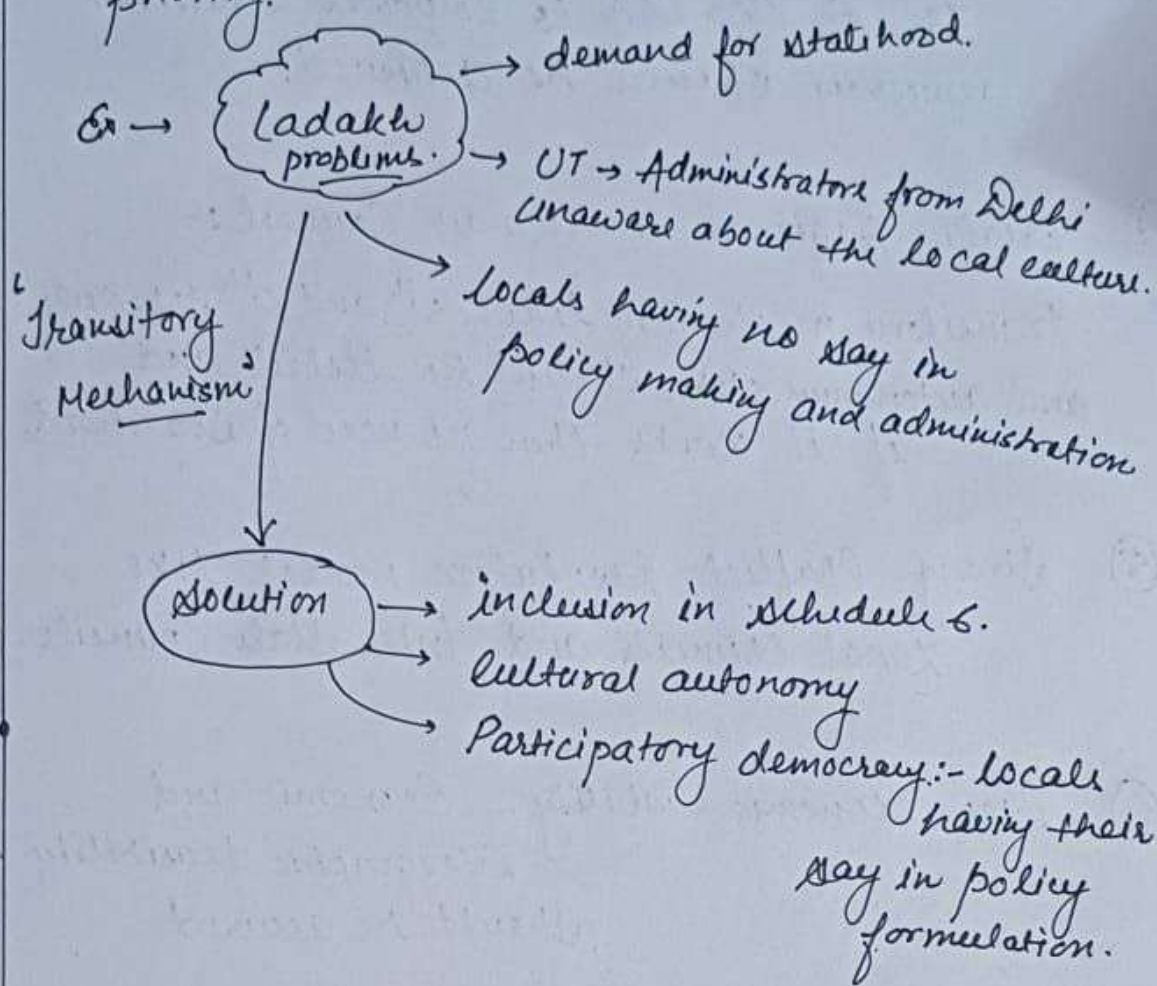
* Weak Border Area:- Fragmentation in strategic regions like border states can weaken national security.

Ex - North Eastern States.

7) Precedential Domino Effect:- Each ^{successful} statehood demand sets a precedent, encouraging further territorial divisions.

Ex - Demand for Bodoland and Harit Pradesh.

formation of new states should be exception and not a rule. The reason behind the demand for the statehood should be the priority.



Root cause / issue should be addressed:-

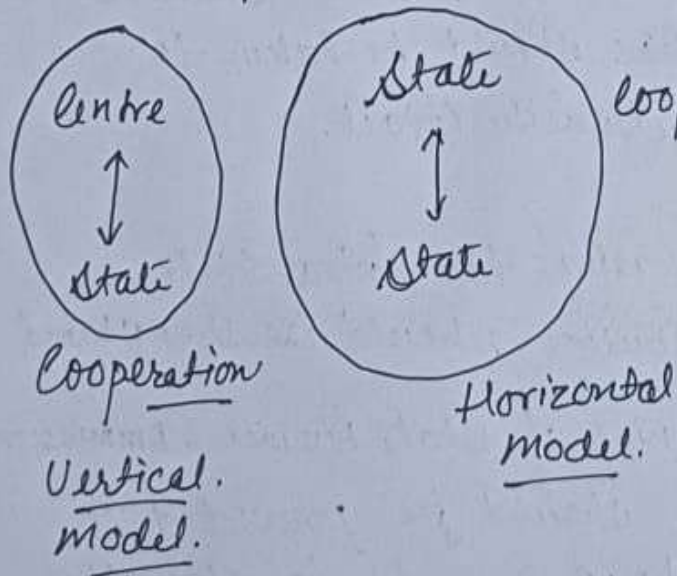
① Effort should be made to preserve cultural diversity → steps should be taken to keep cultural diversity intact.

② Institutions managing the Intra-State resource distribution should be strengthened

Ex → Strengthening of State Finance Commission
* Resources should be provided to PRI's/ULB in order to strengthen them.

mandate given by constitution should be fulfilled by these institutions.

- ③ Administrative decentralization:- Aim of 73rd & 74th CAA to empower Grass Root democracy should be achieved.
- ④ Create regional autonomous Council:-
transitory mechanism like - 5th and 6th schedule and autonomous status should be tested and if it works then no need of statehood.
- ⑤ Strong Conflict Resolution model like Zonal Councils and Inter State Councils.
- ⑥ Geo-Economic Viability - Economic and Geographic feasibility should be assured.
- ⑦ Need to promote Horizontal model of cooperative federalism.



Ex → Bihari residing in Maharashtra getting PDS benefits having ration card of Bihar.
This could happen by state state cooperation.